Appendix S1

Spatiotemporal Graph Neural Networks for Neighborhood-Level Influenza Forecasting in Boston

Contents. Appendix S1 (models, tuning, data notes, and design experience on the development season); Tables S1–S16; Figures S1–S5.

Models

Table S1 lists every model in the evaluation. All learned models were tuned with the same budget in every test season and averaged over 10 training runs, in all 3 cities; all models except the FluSight baseline received forecast intervals from the same shared procedure described in the main text. Table S14 lists which analyses were run in each city and, where one was not, why.

Table S1: Models Compared

Model	What it does	Inputs
Graph neural network	Causal temporal convolutions over each neighborhood's recent weeks, graph convolution over the neighborhood map plus a learned set of extra links, and a learned correction to a blend of the current week and a seasonal curve	16 weeks of rates, 6 weather, 8 demographic measures, map
Same model, map removed	As above with no links between neighborhoods and no surrounding areas	Same, no map
LSTM	Long short-term memory network reading all neighborhoods' series jointly	All series, no map
Cola-GNN	Published influenza graph model that learns connections from the data;[1] reimplemented	All series
Gradient-boosted trees	Regression trees pooled across neighborhoods	Same columns as graph model, no map
Seasonal ARIMA	Per-neighborhood ARIMA with the annual cycle as harmonic regressors	Own history
Seasonal blend, no learning	The graph model's baseline (current week blended with the seasonal curve) with the network switched off	Own history
FluSight baseline	Latest value carried forward, ranges from past changes over the forecast horizon	Own history
Persistence	Next week equals this week	Own history
Climatology	Seasonal curve for the target week	Own history
Same week last year	The value in the same week one year earlier	Own history
Graph attention network[a]	Spatial graph attention over 52 weeks of history, no temporal layer[2,3]	52 weeks, map
Dual-topology GCN[a]	Separate geographic and correlation graphs with temporal convolutions[3]	52 weeks, 2 maps

Abbreviations: ARIMA, autoregressive integrated moving average; GCN, graph convolutional network; LSTM, long short-term memory network.

[a] The comparison and reference models of Luo et al.,[3] run at 1 week ahead only, as in that paper.

Comparison models: ARIMA and LSTM

[Coauthor: describe the ARIMA comparison model here (about 120–170 words).]

[Coauthor: describe the LSTM comparison model here (about 130–180 words).]

Equal-budget tuning

For each learned model, test season, and horizon, 12 configurations were trained once: the model's default and 11 drawn at random from the space in Table S2. The configuration with the lowest mean absolute error on the validation weeks immediately before the test season was retrained with 10 random seeds and scored on the test season. The chosen configurations are recorded in `Code/sweep/tuned_configs.json`.

Table S2: Tuning Search Spaces

Model	Values searched
Graph neural network (with and without map)	learning rate {0.001, 0.003, 0.01}; weight decay {0.0003, 0.001, 0.003, 0.01}; dropout {0.1, 0.25, 0.4}; channels {16, 24, 32}; epochs {80, 120, 200}
LSTM	learning rate {0.0003, 0.001, 0.003}; weight decay {0.00001, 0.0001, 0.001}; dropout {0, 0.1, 0.25}; hidden size {32, 64, 128}; lookback {8, 16, 26} weeks; epochs {80, 120, 200}; target {level, blend}
Gradient-boosted trees	learning rate {0.01, 0.03, 0.1}; maximum depth {2, 3, 4, 6}; minimum child weight {1, 4, 8}; row subsample {0.6, 0.8, 1.0}; column subsample {0.6, 0.8, 1.0}; L2 penalty {0.5, 2, 8}; target {climatology, level, blend}
Cola-GNN	learning rate {0.0003, 0.001, 0.003}; weight decay {0, 0.0005, 0.005}; dropout {0.1, 0.2, 0.4}; hidden size {16, 32, 64}; lookback {12, 20, 26} weeks; epochs {100, 150, 200}
Graph attention network	learning rate {0.001, 0.003, 0.01}; weight decay {0.00001, 0.0001, 0.001}; dropout {0.1, 0.2, 0.4}; hidden size {32, 64}; heads {4, 8}; epochs {100, 200}
Dual-topology GCN	learning rate {0.001, 0.003, 0.01}; weight decay {0.00001, 0.0001, 0.001}; epochs {100, 200}; fusion {concatenate, mean, maximum}

Abbreviations: GCN, graph convolutional network; LSTM, long short-term memory network.

The weighted interval score

The weighted interval score (WIS) asks how far off a forecast was, counting both its best guess and how honest its range was.[4] A close forecast that claims too much certainty should score worse than an equally close one that admits its uncertainty, and a very wide range should not score well only because it happened to contain the observed value.

The WIS is built from the interval score. For a central $(1-\alpha)\times 100\%$ forecast interval from l to u and an observed value y, the interval score is

$$\mathrm{IS}_\alpha(l,u;y) = (u-l) + \frac{2}{\alpha}(l-y)\,\mathbf{1}(y<l) + \frac{2}{\alpha}(y-u)\,\mathbf{1}(y>u),$$

where $\mathbf{1}(\cdot)$ is 1 when the condition holds and 0 otherwise. The first term is the width of the interval; the other 2 are penalties for missing, proportional to how far outside the interval the observation fell. For a 95% interval ($\alpha = 0.05$), each unit of miss costs 40 times as much as each unit of width, so the score is lowest, on average, for an interval that really does contain the outcome 95% of the time.[5]

Every model in this study reports the 23 quantiles used by FluSight: the median (m) and 11 central intervals with $\alpha_k = 0.02, 0.05, 0.10, 0.20, \ldots, 0.90$ (98%, 95%, 90%, 80%, ..., 10% intervals). The WIS combines them:

$$\mathrm{WIS}(y) = \frac{1}{K + \frac{1}{2}} \left(\tfrac{1}{2} |y - m| + \sum_{k=1}^{K} \frac{\alpha_k}{2} \, \mathrm{IS}_{\alpha_k}(l_k, u_k; y) \right), \qquad K = 11.$$

Each interval is weighted by $\alpha_k/2$, so narrow intervals near the median count with small weight and wide intervals with larger weight, and the median alone contributes half its absolute error. The WIS is in the units of the forecast (ED visits for ILI per 100,000, or Chicago's 1–10 levels), and lower is better. A forecast that puts all its quantiles on a single value has a WIS equal to its absolute error, so WIS can be read on the same scale as mean absolute error. The WIS approximates the continuous ranked probability score, a standard score for whole forecast distributions, and is algebraically equal to twice the mean quantile (pinball) loss over the 23 quantiles, which is how the code computes it. Each table reports the mean WIS over neighborhoods and target weeks; relative WIS divides a model's mean WIS by that of persistence.

The WIS can be split exactly into a spread term (the weighted widths, $\sum_k \frac{\alpha_k}{2}(u_k - l_k)$, divided by $K + \frac{1}{2}$) and penalties for forecasting too high or too low (the weighted misses, including the median term). Most of a wide, cautious forecast's score comes from spread, and most of a narrow forecast's score comes from penalties when it misses.

In Boston, the graph neural network's mean WIS 1 week ahead was 5.13 (Table 2 of the main text): its forecasts were off by about 5 ED visits for ILI per 100,000 residents per neighborhood-week, with credit given for honest ranges. For scale, observed rates in the 3 unseen seasons averaged 26.9 per 100,000 (median, 15.5; 90th percentile, 60.9). The WIS is lower than the same forecasts' mean absolute error (7.85; Table S9) because a forecast whose range covers the outcome is charged less than one that commits to a single value. Of the 5.13, about 1.9 came from the width of the ranges, 2.1 from forecasting too low, and 1.2 from forecasting too high. The mean is driven by high weeks. In the tenth of neighborhood-weeks with the highest rates, the average WIS was 16.2, against 3.9 in the rest, and those weeks supplied about a third of the total; a typical (median) week scored 2.8. WIS values cannot be compared across cities with different measures: Boston's (about 5 to 8) are in rates and Chicago's (about 1 to 1.5) in 1–10 levels. Within a city they also rise and fall with how high a season ran, so models are compared with each other on the same weeks. For this reason the main text leads with relative WIS. Persistence's mean WIS 1 week ahead was 6.24, so the graph neural network's relative WIS was $5.13/6.24 = 0.82$, or 18% less error than persistence.

As an example, consider Dorchester. The graph neural network's forecast made on January 19, 2025, for the week of February 2 (2 weeks ahead) had a median of 226.7 per 100,000 and a 95% interval of 175.6 to 292.6. The observed rate was 294.4, just above the 97.5th percentile. The WIS for this forecast was 43.5, of which 6.1 came from spread and 37.4 from underprediction. The model forecast a rise but too low a peak, and nearly all of the score reflects that shortfall. Persistence, which carried forward the 292.5 observed on January 19, scored 9.0 that week. Forecasts that fall short of peaks, as described in the main text, are penalized most because errors are largest where rates are high.[6]

Full results by season

Table S3: Mean Weighted Interval Score by Model, Season, and Horizon, 14 Neighborhoods, Boston, Massachusetts, 2022–2025

	2022–2023			2023–2024			2024–2025		
Model	1 wk	2 wk	4 wk	1 wk	2 wk	4 wk	1 wk	2 wk	4 wk
Graph neural network	5.56	7.70	10.95	4.70	5.07	5.53	5.14	6.64	8.18
Same model, map removed	6.23	7.83	10.86	5.04	5.37	5.98	5.79	6.95	9.20
LSTM	5.50	7.67	11.29	4.85	5.85	6.84	5.20	6.96	9.33
Cola−GNN	6.01	10.37	10.97	4.79	5.29	6.43	5.24	7.17	8.92
Gradient−boosted trees	6.29	8.09	11.31	5.28	5.61	6.34	6.68	8.27	9.49
Seasonal ARIMA	6.29	8.02	10.94	5.43	5.75	5.91	7.84	9.22	10.60
Seasonal blend, no learning	6.26	7.95	11.30	5.63	6.08	6.44	5.97	7.84	10.96
FluSight baseline	6.65	8.55	12.50	5.83	6.52	7.68	6.69	9.41	14.17
Persistence	6.51	8.30	12.38	5.86	6.57	7.87	6.36	8.95	14.07
Graph attention network[a]	6.32			5.08			5.02		
Dual−topology GCN[a]	11.36			5.38			6.45		
Climatology	13.25	13.25	13.21	6.59	6.60	6.60	11.10	11.10	11.10
Same week last year	12.19	12.19	12.19	13.71	13.79	13.79	10.61	10.61	10.61

Values are emergency department visits for influenza-like illness per 100,000 residents; lower is better. wk, weeks ahead.
[a] Run at 1 week ahead only.

Table S4: Mean Weighted Interval Score by Model and Horizon, 17 Areas, Columbus, Ohio, June 2024–May 2025

Model	1 wk	2 wk	4 wk
Graph neural network	4.06	5.03	6.31
Same model, map removed	4.70	5.37	6.39
LSTM	5.13	7.13	6.57
Cola−GNN	6.03	6.75	7.12
Gradient−boosted trees	6.96	5.47	6.59
Seasonal ARIMA	5.55	5.84	6.50
Seasonal blend, no learning	5.05	5.68	6.44
FluSight baseline	4.84	6.10	8.20
Persistence	4.67	5.89	8.45
Graph attention network[a]	7.11		
Dual−topology GCN[a]	8.71		
Climatology	6.75	6.75	6.75
Same week last year	5.75	5.75	5.75

Values are emergency department visits for influenza-like illness per 100,000 residents; lower is better. wk, weeks ahead.
[a] Run at 1 week ahead only.

Table S5: Mean Weighted Interval Score by Model, Season, and Horizon, 58 ZIP Codes, Chicago, Illinois, 2022–2026

	2022–2023			2023–2024			2024–2025			2025–2026		
Model	1	2	4	1	2	4	1	2	4	1	2	4
Graph neural network	1.16	1.31	1.48	1.08	1.14	1.23	1.09	1.13	1.26	1.00	1.07	1.17
Same model, map removed	1.27	1.38	1.56	1.14	1.20	1.26	1.16	1.22	1.31	1.08	1.15	1.20
LSTM	1.22	1.35	1.57	1.13	1.18	1.29	1.15	1.19	1.54	1.04	1.12	1.27
Cola-GNN	1.33	1.41	1.55	1.10	1.16	1.38	1.12	1.16	1.39	1.02	1.09	1.19
Gradient−boosted trees	1.29	1.41	1.51	1.14	1.20	1.27	1.21	1.27	1.37	1.11	1.15	1.20
Seasonal ARIMA	1.31	1.37	1.52	1.17	1.19	1.21	1.25	1.27	1.35	1.10	1.15	1.20
Seasonal blend, no learning	1.37	1.44	1.55	1.18	1.20	1.24	1.28	1.32	1.36	1.15	1.20	1.27
FluSight baseline	1.40	1.48	1.69	1.35	1.42	1.53	1.33	1.39	1.51	1.24	1.32	1.49
Persistence	1.44	1.52	1.68	1.33	1.39	1.48	1.35	1.42	1.52	1.25	1.32	1.50
Graph attention network[a]	1.49			1.16			1.12			1.07		
Dual-topology GCN[a]	1.59			1.43			1.18			1.11		
Climatology	1.69	1.69	1.69	1.28	1.28	1.28	1.51	1.51	1.51	1.26	1.27	1.27
Same week last year	1.76	1.76	1.76	1.63	1.63	1.63	1.57	1.57	1.57	1.47	1.47	1.47

Values are in Chicago Department of Public Health influenza-like illness activity levels (1–10), not rates, so they are not comparable in size with Boston or Columbus; lower is better. Column numbers are weeks ahead. No Chicago season was used in design, so all 4 are unseen. Learned models were tuned with the same budget as in Boston and Columbus.

[a] Run at 1 week ahead only.

Week-level comparisons

Each row compares the graph neural network with one model on the weeks of one season. The difference is graph neural network minus the other model, so a negative value favors the graph neural network. Intervals are 95% confidence intervals from a moving-block bootstrap over weeks (blocks of 4 weeks). *P* values are from the 2-sided Diebold–Mariano test with the Harvey–Leybourne–Newbold correction, Holm-adjusted across every model compared in that season and horizon (including the 1-week-only models and an untuned 10-seed LSTM, which are not shown). The same models enter the adjustment in all 3 cities.

Table S6: Week-Level Differences in Weighted Interval Score, Boston, Massachusetts, 2022–2025

Season	Weeks Ahead	Comparison Model	Difference (95% CI)	Adjusted *P*
2022–2023	1	Same model, map removed	−0.68 (−1.03, −0.36)	<.001
		LSTM	0.06 (−0.22, 0.34)	.62
		Cola-GNN	−0.45 (−1.32, 0.09)	.30
		Gradient-boosted trees	−0.73 (−1.15, −0.37)	<.001
		Seasonal ARIMA	−0.74 (−1.31, −0.37)	<.001
		Seasonal blend, no learning	−0.70 (−1.11, −0.39)	<.001
		FluSight baseline	−1.09 (−2.14, −0.47)	.001
		Persistence	−0.95 (−1.94, −0.31)	.005
2022–2023	2	Same model, map removed	−0.13 (−0.87, 0.60)	>.99
		LSTM	0.03 (−0.78, 0.63)	>.99
		Cola-GNN	−2.67 (−7.23, 0.22)	.95
		Gradient-boosted trees	−0.39 (−0.60, −0.20)	.001
		Seasonal ARIMA	−0.32 (−1.24, 0.57)	>.99
		Seasonal blend, no learning	−0.25 (−1.30, 0.71)	>.99
		FluSight baseline	−0.85 (−3.37, 0.85)	>.99
		Persistence	−0.60 (−3.12, 1.40)	>.99
2022–2023	4	Same model, map removed	0.09 (−0.18, 0.43)	>.99
		LSTM	−0.34 (−3.55, 2.68)	>.99
		Cola-GNN	−0.02 (−2.83, 2.77)	>.99
		Gradient-boosted trees	−0.36 (−0.81, 0.00)	>.99
		Seasonal ARIMA	0.01 (−1.51, 1.81)	>.99
		Seasonal blend, no learning	−0.35 (−2.16, 1.20)	>.99
		FluSight baseline	−1.55 (−6.37, 1.79)	>.99
		Persistence	−1.43 (−6.56, 2.72)	>.99
2023–2024	1	Same model, map removed	−0.34 (−0.48, −0.17)	.009
		LSTM	−0.14 (−0.42, 0.05)	.43
		Cola-GNN	−0.09 (−0.26, 0.05)	.43
		Gradient-boosted trees	−0.57 (−0.80, −0.37)	<.001
		Seasonal ARIMA	−0.73 (−0.95, −0.50)	<.001
		Seasonal blend, no learning	−0.93 (−1.24, −0.66)	<.001
		FluSight baseline	−1.13 (−1.48, −0.84)	<.001
		Persistence	−1.15 (−1.46, −0.88)	<.001
2023–2024	2	Same model, map removed	−0.30 (−0.50, −0.11)	.01
		LSTM	−0.78 (−1.05, −0.51)	<.001
		Cola-GNN	−0.22 (−0.71, 0.18)	.46
		Gradient-boosted trees	−0.54 (−0.77, −0.34)	<.001
		Seasonal ARIMA	−0.68 (−0.98, −0.46)	<.001
		Seasonal blend, no learning	−1.01 (−1.49, −0.68)	<.001

Season	Weeks Ahead	Comparison Model	Difference (95% CI)	Adjusted P
		FluSight baseline	−1.45 (−2.07, −0.99)	<.001
		Persistence	−1.50 (−2.03, −1.06)	<.001
2023–2024	4	Same model, map removed	−0.45 (−0.75, −0.17)	.03
		LSTM	−1.31 (−2.28, −0.53)	.03
		Cola-GNN	−0.90 (−2.10, −0.02)	.10
		Gradient-boosted trees	−0.81 (−1.09, −0.54)	<.001
		Seasonal ARIMA	−0.38 (−0.62, −0.10)	.04
		Seasonal blend, no learning	−0.90 (−1.42, −0.49)	.004
		FluSight baseline	−2.15 (−3.22, −1.35)	<.001
		Persistence	−2.34 (−3.42, −1.47)	<.001
2024–2025	1	Same model, map removed	−0.65 (−1.25, −0.18)	.009
		LSTM	−0.06 (−0.41, 0.25)	>.99
		Cola-GNN	−0.10 (−0.43, 0.24)	>.99
		Gradient-boosted trees	−1.54 (−3.20, −0.51)	.01
		Seasonal ARIMA	−2.70 (−5.17, −1.10)	<.001
		Seasonal blend, no learning	−0.83 (−1.39, −0.41)	<.001
		FluSight baseline	−1.55 (−2.83, −0.67)	.01
		Persistence	−1.22 (−2.41, −0.35)	.04
2024–2025	2	Same model, map removed	−0.31 (−0.57, −0.09)	.08
		LSTM	−0.33 (−0.74, 0.07)	.25
		Cola-GNN	−0.54 (−1.31, 0.06)	.25
		Gradient-boosted trees	−1.63 (−3.53, −0.48)	.19
		Seasonal ARIMA	−2.59 (−4.62, −1.19)	.009
		Seasonal blend, no learning	−1.21 (−1.98, −0.60)	.002
		FluSight baseline	−2.78 (−5.81, −0.86)	.17
		Persistence	−2.31 (−5.12, −0.39)	.19
2024–2025	4	Same model, map removed	−1.01 (−1.82, −0.40)	.06
		LSTM	−1.15 (−2.13, −0.43)	.07
		Cola-GNN	−0.74 (−1.70, −0.02)	.17
		Gradient-boosted trees	−1.31 (−2.69, −0.35)	.17
		Seasonal ARIMA	−2.41 (−3.89, −1.18)	.02
		Seasonal blend, no learning	−2.78 (−4.71, −1.07)	.06
		FluSight baseline	−5.98 (−12.10, −2.04)	.17
		Persistence	−5.88 (−12.08, −1.81)	.17

Table S7: Week-Level Differences in Weighted Interval Score, Columbus, Ohio, 2024–2025

Season	Weeks Ahead	Comparison Model	Difference (95% CI)	Adjusted P
2024–2025	1	Same model, map removed	−0.64 (−1.58, −0.06)	.07
		LSTM	−1.07 (−2.81, −0.08)	.07
		Cola-GNN	−1.96 (−4.87, −0.23)	.05
		Gradient-boosted trees	−2.90 (−7.04, −0.26)	.05
		Seasonal ARIMA	−1.49 (−3.34, −0.30)	.02
		Seasonal blend, no learning	−0.98 (−2.52, −0.04)	.07
		FluSight baseline	−0.78 (−1.47, −0.07)	.05
		Persistence	−0.60 (−1.13, 0.16)	.07
2024–2025	2	Same model, map removed	−0.35 (−1.14, 0.22)	.63
		LSTM	−2.10 (−4.72, −0.33)	.21

		Cola-GNN	−1.73 (−3.91, −0.30)	.23
		Gradient-boosted trees	−0.44 (−1.29, 0.12)	.63
		Seasonal ARIMA	−0.81 (−2.10, 0.02)	.63
		Seasonal blend, no learning	−0.66 (−1.93, 0.14)	.63
		FluSight baseline	−1.07 (−2.64, 0.23)	.63
		Persistence	−0.87 (−1.90, 0.27)	.63
2024–2025	4	Same model, map removed	−0.08 (−0.39, 0.21)	.93
		LSTM	−0.26 (−0.52, −0.10)	.25
		Cola-GNN	−0.80 (−1.44, −0.35)	.10
		Gradient-boosted trees	−0.28 (−0.72, 0.09)	.89
		Seasonal ARIMA	−0.19 (−0.44, 0.07)	.88
		Seasonal blend, no learning	−0.13 (−0.41, 0.13)	.93
		FluSight baseline	−1.88 (−5.62, 1.05)	.93
		Persistence	−2.14 (−4.48, −0.18)	.40

Table S8: Week-Level Differences in Weighted Interval Score, Chicago, Illinois, 2022–2026 (Activity Levels)

Season	Weeks Ahead	Comparison Model	Difference (95% CI)	Adjusted P
2022–2023	1	Same model, map removed	−0.11 (−0.17, −0.05)	<.001
		LSTM	−0.06 (−0.16, 0.00)	.02
		Cola-GNN	−0.17 (−0.43, 0.01)	.02
		Gradient-boosted trees	−0.13 (−0.24, −0.04)	<.001
		Seasonal ARIMA	−0.15 (−0.20, −0.11)	<.001
		Seasonal blend, no learning	−0.21 (−0.39, −0.07)	<.001
		FluSight baseline	−0.24 (−0.32, −0.15)	<.001
		Persistence	−0.28 (−0.35, −0.20)	<.001
2022–2023	2	Same model, map removed	−0.06 (−0.12, −0.03)	.06
		LSTM	−0.03 (−0.18, 0.06)	>.99
		Cola-GNN	−0.09 (−0.27, 0.03)	.63
		Gradient-boosted trees	−0.10 (−0.22, −0.00)	.28
		Seasonal ARIMA	−0.05 (−0.12, 0.05)	.63
		Seasonal blend, no learning	−0.12 (−0.25, −0.03)	.09
		FluSight baseline	−0.17 (−0.32, 0.02)	.09
		Persistence	−0.20 (−0.35, −0.02)	.02
2022–2023	4	Same model, map removed	−0.08 (−0.17, −0.00)	.81
		LSTM	−0.08 (−0.30, 0.10)	>.99
		Cola-GNN	−0.06 (−0.36, 0.14)	>.99
		Gradient-boosted trees	−0.02 (−0.09, 0.05)	>.99
		Seasonal ARIMA	−0.04 (−0.07, 0.01)	.80
		Seasonal blend, no learning	−0.07 (−0.26, 0.10)	>.99
		FluSight baseline	−0.20 (−0.44, 0.05)	.81
		Persistence	−0.20 (−0.40, 0.05)	.81
2023–2024	1	Same model, map removed	−0.06 (−0.10, −0.02)	.002
		LSTM	−0.04 (−0.10, 0.00)	.19
		Cola-GNN	−0.02 (−0.05, 0.01)	.22
		Gradient-boosted trees	−0.06 (−0.09, −0.03)	<.001
		Seasonal ARIMA	−0.09 (−0.12, −0.06)	<.001
		Seasonal blend, no learning	−0.10 (−0.15, −0.05)	<.001
		FluSight baseline	−0.27 (−0.35, −0.18)	<.001

Season	Weeks Ahead	Comparison Model	Difference (95% CI)	Adjusted P
		Persistence	−0.25 (−0.31, −0.18)	<.001
2023–2024	2	Same model, map removed	−0.06 (−0.10, −0.02)	.02
		LSTM	−0.04 (−0.11, 0.01)	.30
		Cola-GNN	−0.02 (−0.07, 0.02)	.30
		Gradient-boosted trees	−0.06 (−0.13, −0.01)	.09
		Seasonal ARIMA	−0.05 (−0.09, −0.02)	.007
		Seasonal blend, no learning	−0.06 (−0.11, −0.02)	.02
		FluSight baseline	−0.28 (−0.38, −0.18)	<.001
		Persistence	−0.25 (−0.32, −0.17)	<.001
2023–2024	4	Same model, map removed	−0.03 (−0.06, −0.00)	.29
		LSTM	−0.06 (−0.08, −0.04)	<.001
		Cola-GNN	−0.15 (−0.30, −0.02)	.30
		Gradient-boosted trees	−0.04 (−0.09, −0.00)	.30
		Seasonal ARIMA	0.02 (−0.02, 0.07)	.75
		Seasonal blend, no learning	−0.01 (−0.04, 0.03)	.75
		FluSight baseline	−0.30 (−0.48, −0.14)	.01
		Persistence	−0.25 (−0.37, −0.14)	.001
2024–2025	1	Same model, map removed	−0.08 (−0.12, −0.04)	<.001
		LSTM	−0.06 (−0.12, −0.02)	.003
		Cola-GNN	−0.03 (−0.05, −0.02)	<.001
		Gradient-boosted trees	−0.13 (−0.22, −0.06)	<.001
		Seasonal ARIMA	−0.16 (−0.27, −0.08)	<.001
		Seasonal blend, no learning	−0.20 (−0.31, −0.12)	<.001
		FluSight baseline	−0.24 (−0.32, −0.16)	<.001
		Persistence	−0.27 (−0.33, −0.21)	<.001
2024–2025	2	Same model, map removed	−0.08 (−0.15, −0.03)	.01
		LSTM	−0.06 (−0.13, −0.00)	.03
		Cola-GNN	−0.03 (−0.05, −0.01)	.02
		Gradient-boosted trees	−0.14 (−0.27, −0.05)	.02
		Seasonal ARIMA	−0.13 (−0.27, −0.04)	.02
		Seasonal blend, no learning	−0.19 (−0.31, −0.09)	<.001
		FluSight baseline	−0.26 (−0.35, −0.17)	<.001
		Persistence	−0.28 (−0.35, −0.21)	<.001
2024–2025	4	Same model, map removed	−0.06 (−0.13, 0.01)	.29
		LSTM	−0.28 (−0.56, −0.07)	.14
		Cola-GNN	−0.14 (−0.18, −0.10)	<.001
		Gradient-boosted trees	−0.11 (−0.19, −0.05)	.02
		Seasonal ARIMA	−0.09 (−0.22, −0.00)	.29
		Seasonal blend, no learning	−0.11 (−0.16, −0.06)	.002
		FluSight baseline	−0.25 (−0.40, −0.11)	.01
		Persistence	−0.26 (−0.37, −0.14)	<.001
2025–2026	1	Same model, map removed	−0.08 (−0.15, −0.04)	.001
		LSTM	−0.04 (−0.06, −0.02)	<.001
		Cola-GNN	−0.02 (−0.03, −0.01)	.003
		Gradient-boosted trees	−0.11 (−0.15, −0.06)	<.001
		Seasonal ARIMA	−0.10 (−0.13, −0.07)	<.001
		Seasonal blend, no learning	−0.15 (−0.17, −0.13)	<.001
		FluSight baseline	−0.24 (−0.30, −0.17)	<.001
		Persistence	−0.25 (−0.30, −0.19)	<.001

Season	Weeks Ahead	Comparison Model	Difference (95% CI)	Adjusted P
2025–2026	2	Same model, map removed	−0.07 (−0.15, −0.02)	.06
		LSTM	−0.05 (−0.07, −0.03)	<.001
		Cola-GNN	−0.02 (−0.04, 0.00)	.08
		Gradient-boosted trees	−0.08 (−0.13, −0.03)	.02
		Seasonal ARIMA	−0.07 (−0.12, −0.04)	.004
		Seasonal blend, no learning	−0.12 (−0.16, −0.08)	<.001
		FluSight baseline	−0.24 (−0.31, −0.17)	<.001
		Persistence	−0.25 (−0.30, −0.19)	<.001
2025–2026	4	Same model, map removed	−0.02 (−0.09, 0.04)	.90
		LSTM	−0.09 (−0.13, −0.05)	<.001
		Cola-GNN	−0.02 (−0.05, 0.01)	.79
		Gradient-boosted trees	−0.03 (−0.08, 0.03)	.90
		Seasonal ARIMA	−0.02 (−0.08, 0.03)	.90
		Seasonal blend, no learning	−0.10 (−0.14, −0.05)	<.001
		FluSight baseline	−0.31 (−0.44, −0.20)	<.001
		Persistence	−0.32 (−0.42, −0.23)	<.001

CI, confidence interval.

Other accuracy measures

WIS is the primary measure because it scores the whole forecast, including its range. Tables S9–S11 give the point measures often reported in earlier work. In all 3 cities the graph neural network had the lowest mean absolute error and root mean squared error at every horizon among the models in Tables S9–S11. Correlation ranks the models differently at some horizons because it ignores whether forecasts are too high or too low overall.

Table S9: Point Forecast Accuracy by Model and Horizon, 14 Neighborhoods, Boston, Massachusetts, 2022–2025

	Mean Absolute Error			Root Mean Squared Error			Correlation[a]		
Model	1 wk	2 wk	4 wk	1 wk	2 wk	4 wk	1 wk	2 wk	4 wk
Graph neural network	7.85	9.63	11.93	12.88	16.99	21.99	0.84	0.76	0.61
Same model, map removed	8.76	10.10	12.57	14.44	17.56	23.13	0.80	0.73	0.57
LSTM	7.96	10.19	13.02	13.18	18.01	24.09	0.87	0.76	0.54
Cola−GNN	8.19	11.04	12.27	13.77	20.56	23.11	0.85	0.70	0.61
Gradient−boosted trees	9.21	10.82	12.99	15.56	19.23	23.73	0.80	0.73	0.57
Seasonal ARIMA	9.69	11.17	13.09	16.45	19.38	23.40	0.78	0.70	0.59
Seasonal blend, no learning	9.06	10.88	13.69	15.07	19.03	25.33	0.79	0.69	0.49
FluSight baseline	9.50	11.89	16.23	15.31	20.21	29.37	0.78	0.68	0.44
Persistence	9.48	11.89	16.22	15.30	20.21	29.37	0.78	0.68	0.44

Errors are ED visits for influenza-like illness per 100,000 residents; lower is better. wk, weeks ahead.
[a] Pearson correlation between forecast and observed rates, computed for each area over the season and averaged across areas; higher is better.

Table S10: Point Forecast Accuracy by Model and Horizon, 17 Areas, Columbus, Ohio, June 2024–May 2025

	Mean Absolute Error			Root Mean Squared Error			Correlation[a]		
Model	1 wk	2 wk	4 wk	1 wk	2 wk	4 wk	1 wk	2 wk	4 wk
Graph neural network	6.02	7.32	8.62	10.17	13.21	16.82	0.83	0.74	0.62
Same model, map removed	7.04	7.65	8.71	12.41	14.41	17.23	0.81	0.75	0.64
LSTM	6.94	8.60	8.78	12.63	16.36	16.85	0.81	0.71	0.57
Cola−GNN	7.99	8.55	9.03	15.40	16.29	17.24	0.77	0.70	0.64
Gradient−boosted trees	9.66	7.67	8.70	18.95	14.47	17.34	0.60	0.75	0.65
Seasonal ARIMA	7.69	8.00	8.85	14.35	15.05	17.04	0.72	0.68	0.53
Seasonal blend, no learning	7.66	8.37	9.10	13.73	15.77	17.62	0.80	0.74	0.64
FluSight baseline	7.28	8.80	11.42	10.98	14.59	20.19	0.79	0.69	0.47
Persistence	7.28	8.80	11.42	10.98	14.59	20.19	0.79	0.69	0.47

Errors are ED visits for influenza-like illness per 100,000 residents; lower is better. wk, weeks ahead.
[a] Pearson correlation between forecast and observed rates, computed for each area over the season and averaged across areas; higher is better.

Table S11: Point Forecast Accuracy by Model and Horizon, 58 ZIP Codes, Chicago, Illinois, 2022–2026

	Mean Absolute Error			Root Mean Squared Error			Correlation[a]		
Model	1 wk	2 wk	4 wk	1 wk	2 wk	4 wk	1 wk	2 wk	4 wk
Graph neural network	1.62	1.75	1.96	2.31	2.47	2.67	0.60	0.54	0.45
Same model, map removed	1.73	1.85	2.03	2.48	2.60	2.77	0.51	0.46	0.39
LSTM	1.75	1.90	2.15	2.38	2.51	2.94	0.62	0.57	0.40
Cola-GNN	1.77	1.90	2.19	2.38	2.51	2.86	0.58	0.53	0.33
Gradient−boosted trees	1.81	1.93	2.04	2.48	2.60	2.74	0.51	0.47	0.42
Seasonal ARIMA	1.83	1.90	2.03	2.53	2.60	2.72	0.52	0.50	0.44
Seasonal blend, no learning	1.86	1.92	2.04	2.62	2.70	2.84	0.50	0.47	0.41
FluSight baseline	1.87	1.99	2.24	2.98	3.13	3.39	0.47	0.42	0.33
Persistence	1.87	1.99	2.24	2.98	3.13	3.39	0.47	0.42	0.33

Errors are in influenza-like illness activity levels (1–10); lower is better. wk, weeks ahead.
[a] Pearson correlation between forecast and observed rates, computed for each area over the season and averaged across areas; higher is better.

Severity alerts

Thresholds. For each neighborhood (or Columbus area), intensity thresholds come from the Moving Epidemic Method,[7] reimplemented in Python following the defaults of the `mem` R package, at the 50th, 90th and 98th percentile levels CDC uses. Each test season uses only earlier, non-pandemic seasons, and data stop the day the test season starts: Boston 2022–2023 uses 2017–2018 and 2018–2019; 2023–2024 adds 2022–2023; 2024–2025 adds 2023–2024. Columbus uses 2022–2023 and 2023–2024. The 2019–2020 through 2021–2022 seasons are left out because COVID-19 truncated or suppressed them. Chicago is not included: its measure is already the health department's graded 1–10 activity level.

Scores. A week is an event when the observed rate is at or above the threshold. The probability score uses each forecast's probability of being at or above the threshold, read from its calibrated 95% interval as a normal distribution; the Brier skill score compares its mean squared error with always

forecasting the pooled share of event weeks. The yes/no score alerts when the best-guess forecast is at or above the threshold; the Peirce skill score is the share of event weeks alerted minus the share of non-event weeks alerted. Both pool all neighborhood-weeks of a city's unseen seasons. Intervals for differences use the moving-block bootstrap of the main text. Code: `Code/compare_severity.py` and `Paper/scripts/make_severity.py`.

Table S12: Skill at Warning of Moderate and High Influenza Weeks, by Model, City, and Horizon, Boston, Massachusetts, and Columbus, Ohio

	Brier Skill Score (probability)						Peirce Skill Score (yes/no)					
	Moderate+			High+			Moderate+			High+		
Model	1	2	4	1	2	4	1	2	4	1	2	4
Boston, Massachusetts, 2022–2025 (3 seasons): 232 moderate and 82 high neighborhood-weeks of 2,103												
Graph neural network	0.61	0.41	0.11	0.40	0.12	−0.07	0.63	0.48	0.07	0.40	0.09	0.00
Same model, map removed	0.54	0.39	0.09	0.35	0.10	−0.07	0.62	0.45	0.06	0.32	0.10	0.00
LSTM	0.59	0.41	0.04	0.40	0.09	−0.05	0.63	0.48	0.06	0.33	0.01	0.00
Cola-GNN	0.57	0.23	0.11	0.39	0.03	−0.03	0.60	0.21	0.07	0.26	0.00	0.00
FluSight baseline	0.50	0.28	−0.16	0.32	−0.12	−0.59	0.67	0.53	0.26	0.59	0.29	0.00
Persistence	0.51	0.31	−0.09	0.37	−0.03	−0.51	0.67	0.53	0.26	0.59	0.29	0.00
Columbus, Ohio, 2024–2025: 248 moderate and 107 high neighborhood-weeks of 884												
Graph neural network	0.55	0.51	0.33	0.52	0.30	−0.04	0.68	0.65	0.35	0.51	0.36	0.02
Same model, map removed	0.51	0.48	0.31	0.38	0.20	−0.06	0.61	0.54	0.24	0.34	0.13	0.00
LSTM	0.54	0.36	0.29	0.36	−0.01	−0.04	0.66	0.32	0.42	0.16	0.00	0.02
Cola-GNN	0.46	0.37	0.30	0.02	−0.01	−0.08	0.49	0.34	0.13	0.00	0.00	0.00
FluSight baseline	0.42	0.36	0.14	0.42	0.22	−0.19	0.60	0.58	0.43	0.65	0.52	0.26
Persistence	0.43	0.37	0.17	0.44	0.26	−0.09	0.60	0.58	0.43	0.65	0.52	0.26

Column numbers are weeks ahead. Moderate+, at or above the 50th-percentile intensity threshold; High+, at or above the 90th. Scores above 0 show skill; higher is better. LSTM, long short-term memory network.

Table S13: Weeks Late in First Crossing a Neighborhood's Moderate Threshold, Median Over Area-Seasons

	Boston			Columbus		
Model	1 wk	2 wk	4 wk	1 wk	2 wk	4 wk
Graph neural network	1	2	6	3	7	9
Same model, map removed	1	2	7	7	10	11.5
LSTM	1	3	4	8	15	5
Cola-GNN	1	3	5	14	15	8
FluSight baseline	1	2	4	1	2	4
Persistence	1	2	4	1	2	4

Positive values mean the forecast first crossed the threshold after the observed rate did; persistence is late by exactly the horizon by construction. Area-seasons in which the forecast never crossed are not included. wk, weeks ahead.

Table S14: Analyses Performed in Each City

Analysis	Boston	Columbus	Chicago
Training data used	December 2017 onward	July 2022 onward[a]	September 2019 onward
Unseen test seasons	3 (2022–2023 to 2024–2025)	1 (2024–2025)	4 (2022–2023 to 2025–2026)
Development season (not evidence)	2025–2026	2025–2026	None[b]
Models compared (Table S1)	All 13	All 13	All 13
Equal-budget tuning, 10 training runs	Yes	Yes	Yes
Week-level tests (Tables S6–S8)	Yes	Yes	Yes
Cross-city transfer (main text, Table 4)	Target and source	Target and source	Target and source
Training on several cities at once (Table S15)	Target and source	Target and source	Target and source
Hand-drawn vs automatically built map (main text, Table 3)	Yes	Not applicable[c]	Not applicable[c]
Severity alerts (Tables S12, S13)	Yes	Yes	Not applicable[d]
Map effect by neighborhood; example forecasts and calibration (main text, Figures 4, 5)	Yes	Not shown[e]	Not shown[e]
Design experiments on the development season (Table S16)	Yes	No[f]	No[f]

[a] Influenza nearly disappeared in the first pandemic year, and the Columbus series begins in January 2022, so models start after it; a 2023–2024 test season would have had under 1 year of training data.
[b] Chicago was added after the design was fixed; tuning used only the weeks before each test season.
[c] Only Boston had a hand-drawn map. The Columbus and Chicago maps were built from boundary files from the start, by the rule tested in Table 3.
[d] Chicago's measure is already the health department's graded 1–10 activity level, so there is no rate on which to set intensity thresholds.
[e] Illustrative figures for the primary city; the numbers they summarize for the other cities are in Tables S4, S5, S7, and S8.
[f] The model's structure was chosen on Boston's development season only.

Analyses performed in each city

Training on several cities at once

Because Columbus is forecast about as well by a Boston-trained model as by its own, we asked whether training on more than 1 city helps further. We used the same model and settings as in Table 4 of the main text (no neighborhood-specific learned links, settings fixed in advance, 10 training runs of 120 passes) and trained it on several cities together, using only weeks before the 2024–2025 test season in each. Each city kept its own map, its own scaling (each area's series standardized by its own training-period mean and standard deviation), and its own validation weeks. Every training batch came from 1 city, each city supplied the same number of batches per pass so that Chicago's 58 areas did not outweigh Boston's 14 or Columbus's 17, and the stopping point was chosen on the average of the 3 cities' validation errors. We trained 2 versions: one on all 3 cities, which includes the target city's own earlier weeks, and one on the other 2 cities only, which, like the transferred models of Table 4, has seen no data from the target. Each was applied to each

city's 2024–2025 season as is and after fine-tuning on local data, and compared week by week with the model trained on the target city alone (Holm adjustment over the 4 multicity versions at each horizon).

No multicity model was clearly more accurate than the locally trained one (Table S15). In Columbus, every multicity version had lower mean WIS than the local model at every horizon, by 3% to 8%, but none of these differences was clear (adjusted P values .06 to .40). The model trained on Boston and Chicago, with no Columbus data, beat the Boston-only model of Table 4 at 1, 2, and 4 weeks (3.85 vs 3.90, 4.80 vs 5.08, and 5.97 vs 6.45), clearly at 2 weeks ($P = .006$) and nearly so at 4 weeks ($P = .06$). In Boston and Chicago, which have long histories, their own data were best. Without further training, the multicity models were worse than the local ones at every horizon in both cities, clearly in 3 of the 4 Chicago comparisons at 1 and 2 weeks; after fine-tuning they tied the local models in all 12 comparisons. Training on 2 cities instead of 1 did not help Boston (adjusted $P > .99$ against each single-city source) and helped Chicago only slightly, clearly at 1 week (1.14 vs 1.16, $P = .04$) but not at 2 or 4 weeks.

Table S15: Forecast Error When the Model Is Trained on Several Cities at Once, Boston, Massachusetts; Columbus, Ohio; and Chicago, Illinois, Unseen Season June 2024–May 2025

			Trained on All 3 Cities[b]		Trained on the Other 2 Cities[c]		
Target City	Weeks Ahead	Trained Locally	As Is	Fine-Tuned	As Is	Fine-Tuned	Persistence
Boston	1	4.88	5.13	4.85	5.33	4.80	6.36
	2	6.15	6.63	6.07	6.96	6.34	8.95
	4	8.25	9.16	8.39	10.11	8.12	14.07
Columbus	1	4.11	3.87	4.00	3.85	3.95	4.67
	2	5.18	4.81	4.99	4.80	4.96	5.89
	4	6.49	6.02	5.95	5.97	6.07	8.45
Chicago[d]	1	1.09	1.10	1.08	1.14[a]	1.08	1.35
	2	1.12	1.15[a]	1.13	1.23[a]	1.12	1.42
	4	1.25	1.28	1.24	1.30	1.24	1.52

Abbreviations: WIS, weighted interval score.

Values are mean WIS in the target city's units: ED visits for influenza-like illness per 100,000 residents in Boston and Columbus, and the health department's 1–10 activity level in Chicago. Compare columns within a row, not values across cities. "Trained locally" and "Persistence" are the same as in Table 4 of the main text.

[a] Clearly different from the locally trained model (Holm-adjusted Diebold–Mariano $P < .05$); all 3 marked values are worse.

[b] Includes the target city's own weeks before the test season.

[c] No data from the target city; comparable to the transferred models of Table 4.

[d] Each area's series is scaled by its own training-period mean and standard deviation, so models trained elsewhere forecast in standardized units that are converted back to levels.

Supplementary figures

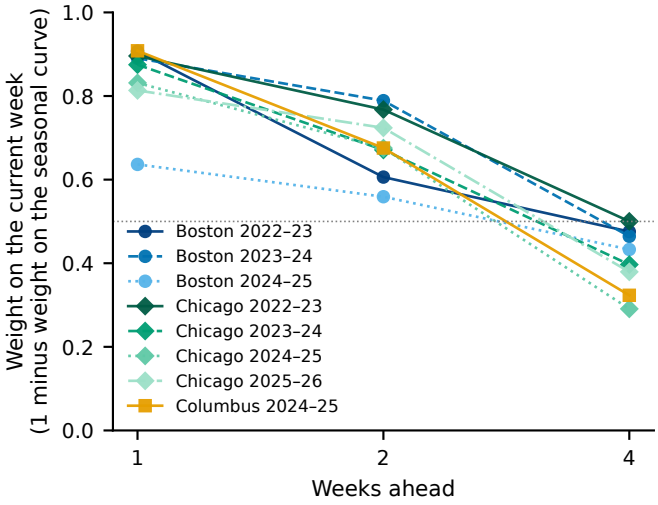


Figure S1. What the graph neural network leans on, by horizon, city, and unseen season. The model's baseline blends the current week's rate with the usual rate for that time of year; the y-axis is the learned weight on the current week (the rest goes to the seasonal curve). At 0.8 to 0.9 at 1 week in most seasons, the model mostly carries the latest value forward; by 4 weeks, it leans at least as much on the seasonal pattern. Boston, Massachusetts, 2022–2025; Columbus, Ohio, 2024–2025; Chicago, Illinois, 2022–2026.

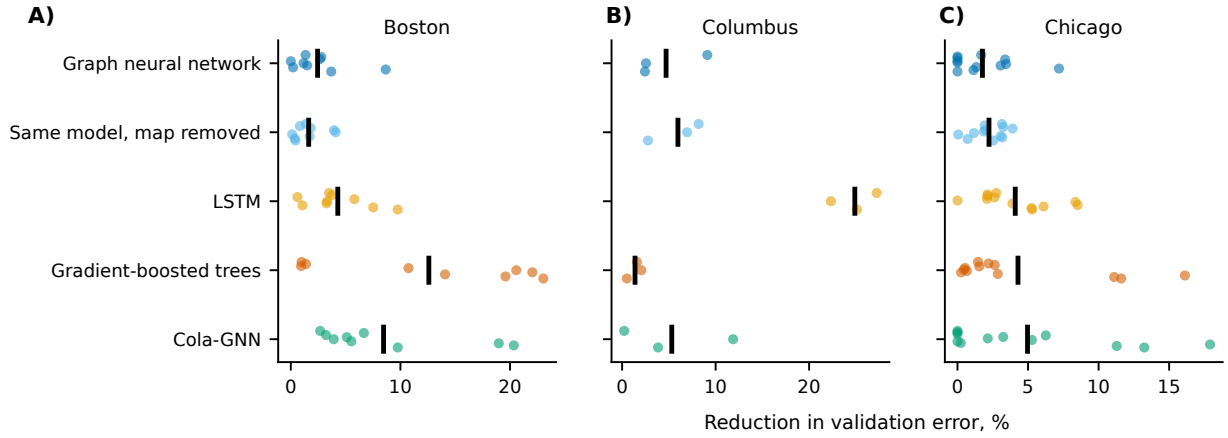


Figure S2. How much equal-budget tuning improved each model, by city: A) Boston, Massachusetts; B) Columbus, Ohio; C) Chicago, Illinois. Each dot is 1 test season and horizon; the percentage is the reduction in mean absolute error on validation weeks for the chosen settings compared with the model's default settings. Black bars are means. LSTM, long short-term memory network.

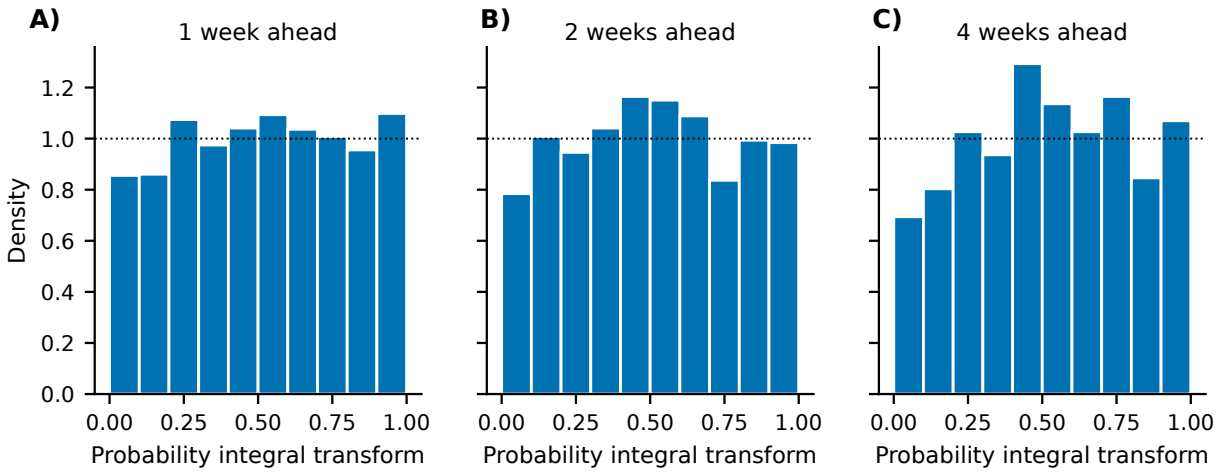


Figure S3. Calibration of the graph neural network's forecast distributions, 14 neighborhoods, Boston, Massachusetts, June 2022–May 2025: A) 1 week, B) 2 weeks, and C) 4 weeks ahead. Each histogram shows where observed values fell within the forecast distribution (the probability integral transform). A flat histogram at the dotted line means well-calibrated forecasts; a U shape would mean ranges that are too narrow, and a hump ranges that are too wide.

Data notes by city

Inputs shared by all cities. The 6 weekly weather variables are mean, maximum, and minimum temperature, relative humidity, precipitation, and maximum wind speed, from the Open-Meteo archive. The 8 demographic measures in all 3 cities are population density, poverty, share of children, share aged 65 years or older, homeownership, transit commuting, households without a vehicle, and share of nonwhite residents, from city planning tables in Boston and from American Community Survey 5-year estimates in Columbus and Chicago. Each measure is scaled within its own city.

Boston. Rates are published weekly by the Boston Public Health Commission for 14 neighborhoods (Back Bay, Beacon Hill, Downtown, North End, and West End form a single neighborhood). Suppressed weeks were treated as missing and excluded from training and scoring. Two data-loading errors found during the project (a count row averaged with the rate row, and suppressed weeks read as zero) were corrected before any result reported here was produced.

Columbus. Visit-level ED records for influenza-like illness from Columbus Public Health were assigned to 17 planning areas through the department's ZIP code crosswalk. Population denominators come from the American Community Survey 5-year estimates summed over ZIP code tabulation areas. Areas with no visits in a week are recorded as observed zeros. The 5 surrounding areas in the map are fringe ZIP codes (43002, 43035, 43140, 43146, and 43240) that the crosswalk lists but leaves unassigned to any planning area; they carry 0.2% of visits.

Chicago. The Chicago Department of Public Health publishes a weekly influenza-like illness activity level for each ZIP code on the City of Chicago Data Portal (dataset 8vvr-jv2g), compiled from Illinois emergency department syndromic surveillance. The level compares a ZIP code's share of emergency department visits for influenza-like illness with that ZIP code's own summer average: level 1 is at or below it, each level above is roughly 1 more standard deviation, and the scale stops at 10, which 13% of ZIP-weeks reach. Because it is an index with no denominator, errors are in levels and cannot be compared in size with the other cities. The series begins in September 2019; the city

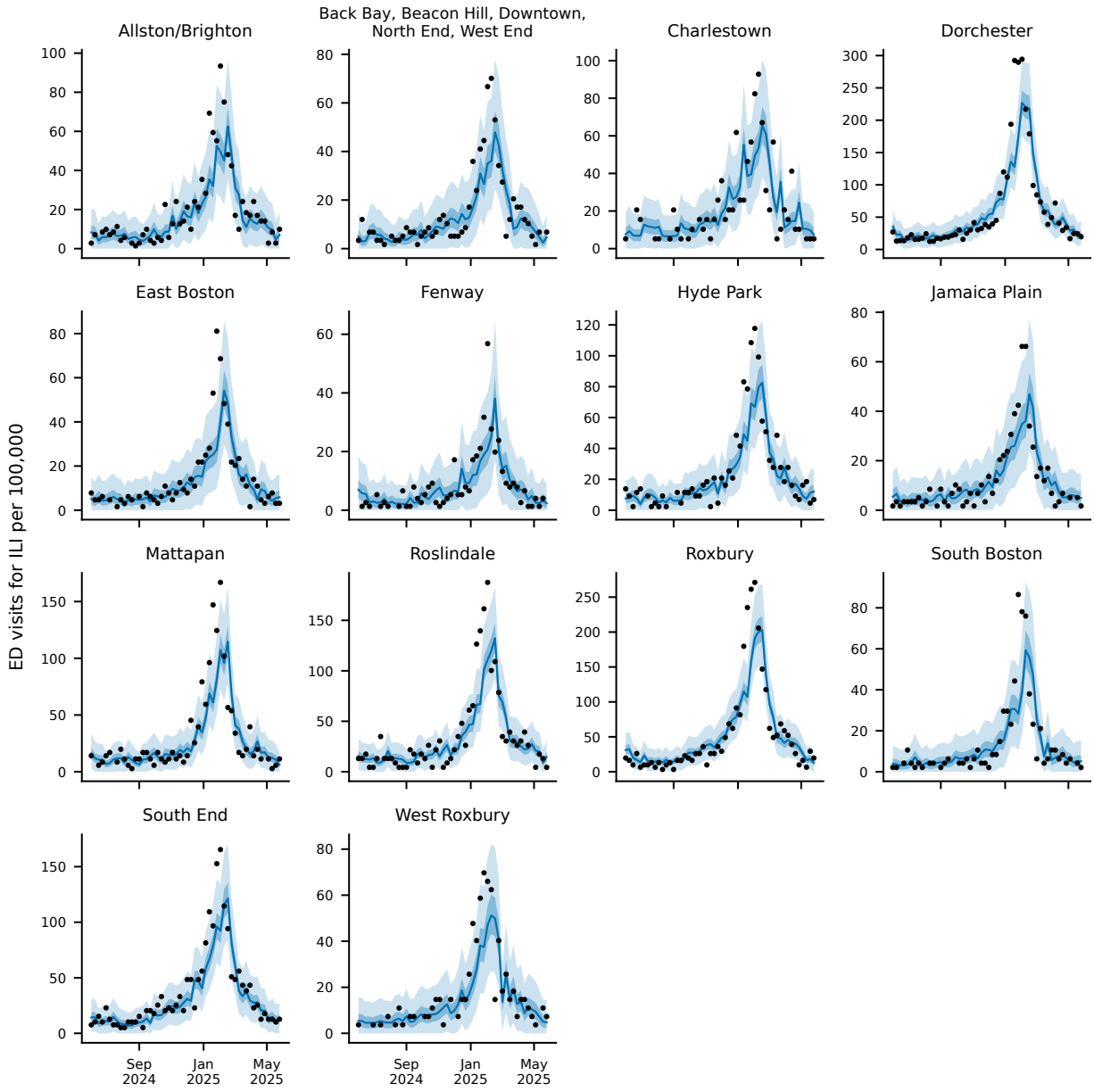


Figure S4. Forecasts made 2 weeks ahead for all 14 neighborhoods, Boston, Massachusetts, June 2024–May 2025. Lines show the graph neural network's median forecast, shading its 50% and 95% forecast intervals, and dots the observed emergency department visit rates for influenza-like illness (ILI) per 100,000 residents. Vertical scales differ by neighborhood.

is absent for May–September 2020, and those weeks are missing. Of 60 ZIP codes, 1 (60106, mostly outside the city) has no boundary and is dropped, and 1 (60827) that joined the feed in September 2020 is in the map but not scored, leaving 58. O'Hare (60666) has no residents and takes the city median for its demographic measures. The map has 115 shared borders, derived from the city's ZIP code boundary file. Models were trained on all weeks from September 2019, and every Chicago season from 2022–2023 to 2025–2026 is unseen. One ZIP code (60707) reported level 1 in every week before June 2022, so in the 2022–2023 training data its series had no variation. Each series

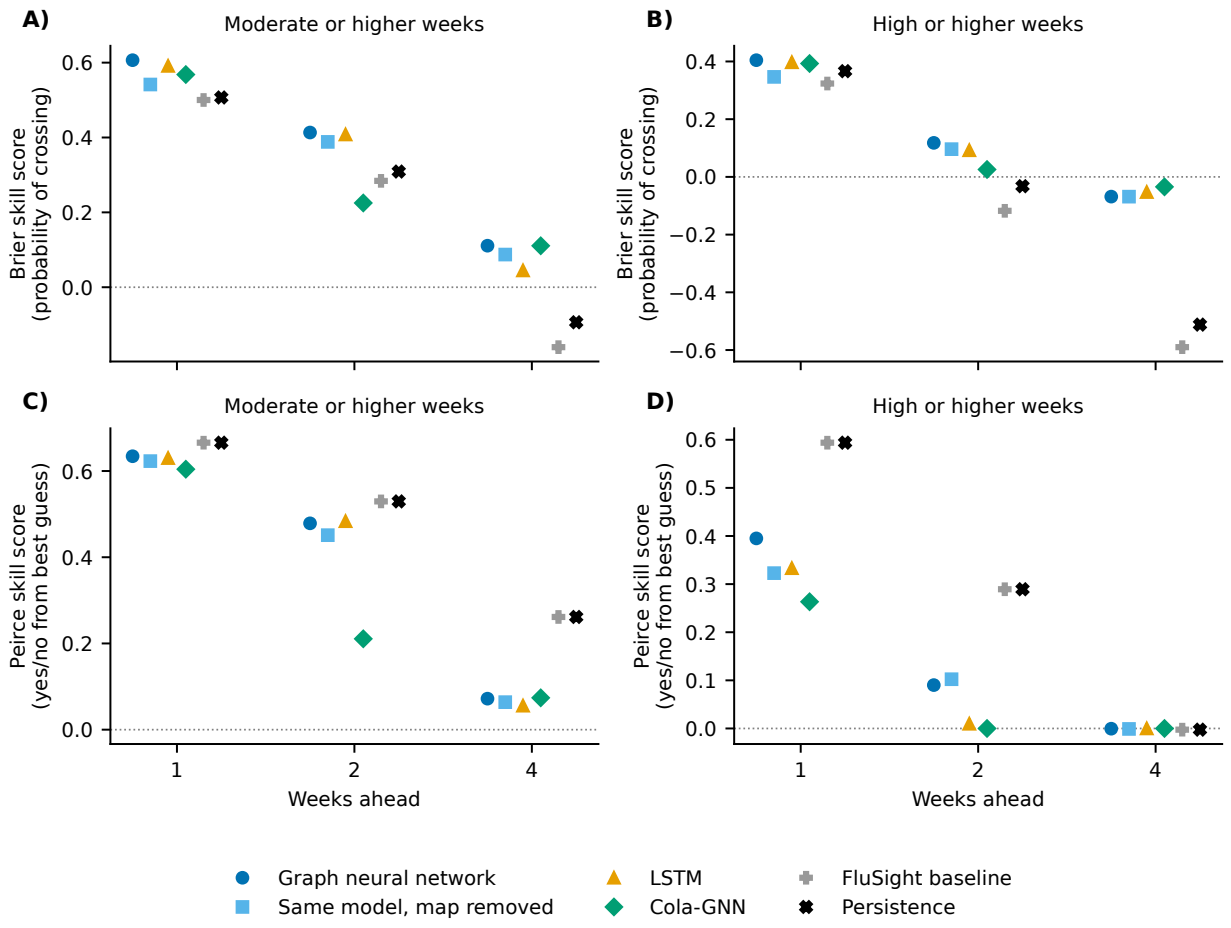


Figure S5. Skill at warning of moderate and high influenza weeks, 14 neighborhoods, Boston, Massachusetts, June 2022–May 2025. A, B) Brier skill score of the forecast's probability of being at or above the moderate (A) or high (B) threshold. C, D) Peirce skill score of a yes/no alert issued when the best-guess forecast is at or above the threshold. Values above the dotted line at 0 show skill. LSTM, long short-term memory network.

is scaled by its training-period standard deviation; a series with none is scaled by 1 instead, which leaves every other series and city unchanged. An earlier run that divided by a near-zero value gave that ZIP code test inputs near 10^9, which graph models passed to its neighbors; all 2022–2023 Chicago results reported here are from the corrected runs.

Design experience on the development season

Before the test seasons were scored, we chose the model's structure on the development season (2025–2026 in Boston; models trained on weeks from July 2022). To decide what to keep, we changed one part of the model at a time, retrained it from scratch with 10 training runs, and asked whether the change made its forecasts rise and fall more closely with what happened in each neighborhood. The measure is the correlation between forecast and observed rates, averaged over the 14 neighborhoods; Table S16 gives each change minus the default, so a positive value means the changed model tracked the observed curve better. To judge how large a difference has to be

before it means anything, we trained the default 3 times on different random starting points. Those 3 results differed by up to 0.003, 0.006, and 0.031 at 1, 2, and 4 weeks, so smaller differences are within run-to-run noise. The table also counts the neighborhoods in which the change raised the correlation. These results were used only to make design choices. They come from the season used to design the model and are not evidence of performance, which comes from the unseen seasons in the main text, where removing the map is tested week by week (Figure 3A).

Removing all links between neighborhoods lowered the correlation by 0.075 at 1 week and 0.093 at 2 weeks, in every neighborhood, but made no difference beyond noise at 4 weeks. Which links were used mattered much less. Keeping borders only, or removing the correlation or demographic links, changed the correlation by 0.006 or less at 1 and 2 weeks, and so did keeping only the links the model learns for itself. Removing weather lowered the correlation at every horizon and in every neighborhood. The 8 demographic measures did not help as inputs: removing them changed the correlation by 0.003 or less at 1 and 2 weeks and raised it by 0.027 at 4 weeks, in all 14 neighborhoods. They remained in the evaluated model. The blended baseline mattered most at 4 weeks, where replacing it with the current week alone lowered the correlation by 0.096.

Of the inputs we tried adding, Boston's influenza wastewater series raised the correlation by 0.089 at 4 weeks, in all 14 neighborhoods, but lowered it by 0.017 at 1 week. The series begins in July 2024 and covers under half of the training period, so the 4-week gain is uncertain, and wastewater was not part of the evaluated model. Statewide vaccination uptake also helped at 4 weeks (0.041). Neighborhood COVID-19 and RSV rates with COVID-19 wastewater made forecasts worse at every horizon. Links weighted by public transit ridership, measured in a separate study, changed the correlation by -0.001, -0.007, and $+0.015$; nearly every transit link duplicated an existing link. Finally, in an earlier, untuned run of our reimplementation of the dual-topology model of Luo et al.,[3] adding a node for the surrounding area raised the correlation from 0.412 to 0.417, compared with the 0.135 gain reported in the original study.

Table S16: Change in Forecast Correlation When One Part of the Graph Neural Network Is Removed, Changed, or Added, Development Season, Boston, Massachusetts, June 2025–May 2026

	Change in Correlation (Neighborhoods Improved)[a]		
Part of the Model	1 Week Ahead	2 Weeks Ahead	4 Weeks Ahead
Removed			
All links between neighborhoods (map and learned)	−0.075 (0)	−0.093 (0)	−0.009 (6)
Hand-built links, keeping learned links	+0.006 (11)	−0.006 (3)	+0.006 (9)
Learned links, keeping hand-built links	−0.011 (0)	−0.007 (4)	+0.016 (14)
Correlation and demographic links (borders only)	+0.001 (9)	−0.004 (2)	−0.009 (0)
Correlation links	0.000 (9)	−0.003 (3)	+0.028 (13)
Demographic links	+0.003 (13)	+0.002 (9)	−0.001 (4)
Demographic measures as inputs	0.000 (6)	−0.003 (4)	+0.027 (14)
Demographic measures and links	+0.001 (9)	−0.002 (5)	+0.008 (13)
Weather	−0.012 (0)	−0.031 (0)	−0.025 (0)
Flag for suppressed weeks	−0.002 (5)	+0.006 (12)	+0.002 (8)
All inputs except past rates	−0.012 (0)	−0.008 (2)	−0.023 (1)
Correlation term in the training loss	−0.001 (3)	−0.006 (1)	+0.007 (11)
Changed			
Baseline: current week only	−0.010 (0)	−0.019 (1)	−0.096 (0)
No baseline	0.000 (7)	−0.059 (2)	−0.029 (3)
Link types kept separate	0.000 (9)	−0.011 (0)	−0.004 (5)
Smaller model	−0.005 (3)	−0.007 (2)	−0.003 (6)
Added			
Influenza wastewater	−0.017 (3)	+0.013 (11)	+0.089 (14)
Statewide vaccination uptake	0.000 (7)	+0.008 (13)	+0.041 (14)
Citywide ILI share	−0.004 (4)	−0.006 (2)	+0.021 (14)
Calendar terms	−0.001 (6)	−0.001 (8)	+0.025 (13)
COVID-19 and RSV rates, COVID-19 wastewater	−0.031 (0)	−0.155 (0)	−0.159 (0)
Transit ridership links[b]	−0.001	−0.007	+0.015

Abbreviations: ILI, influenza-like illness; RSV, respiratory syncytial virus.
The default model's mean correlation was 0.893, 0.802, and 0.582 at 1, 2, and 4 weeks. Not evidence of performance: this season was used to design the model.
[a] Mean per-neighborhood correlation between forecast and observed rates for the changed model minus the default, each averaged over 10 training runs; positive values favor the change. In parentheses, the number of the 14 neighborhoods in which the change raised the correlation. Differences within 0.003, 0.006, and 0.031 at 1, 2, and 4 weeks are within run-to-run noise.
[b] Separate study with the same default; per-neighborhood counts are not available.

References

1. Deng S, Wang S, Rangwala H, et al. Cola-GNN: Cross-location Attention based Graph Neural Networks for Long-term ILI Prediction. In: Proceedings of the 29th ACM International Conference on Information & Knowledge Management. CIKM '20. New York, NY: ACM; 2020. p. 245-254. doi:10.1145/3340531.3411975.

2. Veličković P, Cucurull G, Casanova A, et al. Graph attention networks. In: Proceedings of the 6th International Conference on Learning Representations (ICLR 2018). Vancouver, Canada; 2018. arXiv:1710.10903.

3. Luo J, Wang X, Fan X, et al. A novel graph neural network based approach for influenza-like illness nowcasting: exploring the interplay of temporal, geographical, and functional spatial features. BMC Public Health. 2025;25(1):408. doi:10.1186/s12889-025-21618-6.

4. Bracher J, Ray EL, Gneiting T, et al. Evaluating epidemic forecasts in an interval format. PLoS Comput Biol. 2021;17(2):e1008618. doi:10.1371/journal.pcbi.1008618.

5. Gneiting T, Raftery AE. Strictly Proper Scoring Rules, Prediction, and Estimation. J Am Stat Assoc. 2007;102(477):359-378. doi:10.1198/016214506000001437.

6. Bosse NI, Abbott S, Cori A, et al. Scoring epidemiological forecasts on transformed scales. PLoS Comput Biol. 2023;19(8):e1011393. doi:10.1371/journal.pcbi.1011393.

7. Vega T, Lozano JE, Meerhoff T, et al. Influenza surveillance in Europe: establishing epidemic thresholds by the Moving Epidemic Method. Influenza Other Respir Viruses. 2013;7(4):546-558. doi:10.1111/j.1750-2659.2012.00422.x.